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An Apocryphal Early Life

WE DON'T KNOW EXACTLY WHEN ASHOKA WAS BORN. That he was born sometime in the cusp of the fourth and third century BCE (*c*. 304 BCE) is certain, but the particular day, month, and year is not known. Very few ancient writers share our modern obsession with recording such events with calendrical exactness, and certainly Ashoka's scribes cannot be counted in this category. Date precision in relation to an individual life came into existence much after Ashoka's time, usually when a court chronicler penned the biography of a ruler-patron. Harshavardhana, who ruled from Kanauj in North India nearly 900 years after Ashoka, was one such king whose court poet, Bana, made him the central character in a historical story woven out of the actual events of his reign. There, the month of Harsha's conception, along with his date of birth, were recorded, as also the fact that he was born just after 'the twilight time'.[1] Such precision grows commoner in medieval India, when accounts authorized by powerful emperors come frequently to be composed during their own lifetime. Akbar commissioned his court historian, Abu'l Fazl, to write what became the *Akbar Nama*, whose eponymous hero is recorded as having been born in Sindh, complete with all manner of extraordinary phenomena that heralded his arrival in the sixteenth century, including a strange light perceptible on the brows of his mother when she was pregnant with him.[2]

Ancient India's royal biographical tradition begins several centuries after Ashoka, which is why we merely know that his father Bindusara ruled from roughly 297 till 273 BCE, and that his grandfather Chandragupta's regnal dates are probably 321–297 BCE. The likely year of Ashoka's birth is